

Onyx — Developer Guide

Onyx · multi-process OS on Raspberry Pi 4

This guide explains how to **build** Onyx, how to **write an application** or a **/bin tool**, how to **extend the kapi ABI**, and the **conventions** + **pitfalls** to be aware of. For the details of how things work internally, see [Kernel internals](#).

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1. Prerequisites and toolchain

- **AArch64 bare-metal toolchain**: aarch64-none-elf- (GCC), used under **WSL** on a Windows development machine.
- **Circle**, cloned **next to** the kernel tree (in `Zircon/circle/`).
- `make`, `cp`, `mkdir` (standard Unix tools, via WSL).
- A **FAT32 SD card** and a **Raspberry Pi 4** to run on (there is no QEMU `raspi4b` in the reference dev environment; bring-up is done directly on hardware).

Important — which Circle? The Circle to modify is `Zircon/circle` (the clone next to the kernel), **not** any `C:\Temp\circle`. If you patch Circle (e.g. a keymap), do it in `Zircon/circle` and rebuild the affected library.

2. Building Circle (once)

```
# From the repo root (Zircon/), clone Circle next to the kernel:
git clone --recurse-submodules https://github.com/rsta2/circle.git
```

```
# Circle was checked out as CRLF on Windows -> renormalize to LF once:
git -C circle config core.autocrlf false && git -C circle rm --cached -rq . && git -C circle
reset --hard
```

```
# Configure for RPi 4 / AArch64. DEPTH=32 is REQUIRED: our GImage renders 32-bit
# pixels (Circle defaults to 16).
```

```
cd circle && ./configure -r 4 -p aarch64-none-elf- -d DEPTH=32 -f
```

Build the libraries used by the kernel:

```
(cd lib && make -j4) \
&& (cd lib/sched && make -j4) \
&& (cd lib/fs && make -j4 && cd fat && make -j4) \
&& (cd lib/usb && make -j4) \
&& (cd lib/input && make -j4) \
&& (cd addon/SDCard && make -j4) \
&& (cd addon/fatfs && make -j4)
cd ..
```

If you change DEPTH later, run `make clean` in `circle/lib` before rebuilding (the `.o` files do not depend on `Config.mk`).

The libraries linked by the kernel (cf. `kernel/Makefile`): `libsched.a`, `libfatfs.a`, `libsdcard.a`, `libfs.a`, `libusb.a`, `libinput.a`, `libcircle.a`.

3. Building the kernel and applications

From `kernel/`:

```
cd kernel
make          # -> kernel8-rpi4.img, THEN builds the apps (../user)
```

The default target (`all`):

1. compiles our sources + links against the Circle libs → `kernel8-rpi4.img`;
2. triggers `make -C ../user`, which builds **all the apps** (`user/*.elf`) and the **/bin tools** (`user/bin/*.elf`).

Kernel → apps order. Since the apps go through the **fixed-address ABI table** and are **not** linked against the kernel's addresses, they no longer depend on the kernel build: a *kernel-only* change (that respects the ABI) does **not** require recompiling the apps. `make` rebuilds them anyway for convenience.

Details of the kernel wiring (which Circle files we replace, the order of the `-I compat` `-I include` include path before `circle/include`): see [Kernel internals §1](#) and `kernel/Makefile`.

4. Deploying to the SD card

```
cd kernel
make stage    # copie l'image + chaque app + chaque outil vers ../sdcard/
```

`make stage`:

- copies `kernel8-rpi4.img` → `sdcard/`;
- for each `../user/<name>.elf`: creates `sdcard/apps/<name>.app/` and copies the ELF into it as **main.elf** (the "Onyx" layout);
- copies each `../user/bin/<tool>.elf` → `sdcard/bin/<tool>.elf`.

Then copy **all** of the contents of `sdcard/` onto a **FAT32** card and boot the Pi 4. See the [user guide](#) for details about the card and the configuration files.

5. The application model

A Onyx application is a **single .c file** compiled into a **freestanding ELF** and run in **EL1** in its own page table.

Runtime (user/crt0.S):

```
_start:
    stp x29, x30, [sp, #-16]!    /* the stack is already set up by the kernel */
    bl  main                    /* call main() */
    ldp x29, x30, [sp], #16
    ret                          /* return -> the kernel terminates the task */
```

No argv is passed via the stack: `main()` takes no arguments. An app retrieves its argument line via `kapi_get_args(buf, size)`, and exits early with `kapi_exit(status)`.

Linking (user/user.ld): everything is linked at **USER_VA_BASE = 8 GB** (`. = 0x200000000`). This is **not PIE**. The RX (`.text/.rodata`) and RW (`.data/.bss`) sections are aligned on **64 KB** (`-z max-page-size=0x10000`) so that the loader maps them onto distinct pages. **No kernel symbol** is resolved at link time: everything goes through the ABI table.

Compilation flags (user/Makefile):

```
-ffreestanding -nostdlib -fno-pic -fno-pie -mgeneral-regs-only \
-O2 -Wall -Wextra -fno-stack-protector -I../kernel/include
```

- `-ffreestanding -nostdlib`: **no libc**. No `printf`, `malloc`, `string.h`... use `applib.h` (§8) and static/local buffers.
- `-mgeneral-regs-only`: **no FP/SIMD** — the kernel trap frame does not save the floating-point registers. Do **integer / fixed-point arithmetic** (see `tinycalc.c`, `mandelbrot.c`).
- `-I../kernel/include`: to include `<kern/kapi_abi.h>` (the shared ABI structure).

To add an app, create `user/<name>.c` and **add <name>.elf to the PROGS variable** of `user/Makefile` (and `<tool>.elf` to the `PROGS` of `user/bin/Makefile` for a tool).

6. Writing a graphical application

Minimal skeleton (window with kernel-managed widgets):

```
#include "kapi.h"

static void on_ok (unsigned long sender, int ev, long value)
{
    (void) sender; (void) ev; (void) value;
    kapi_widget_set_text (g_label, "cliqué !");
}

static unsigned long g_label;

int main (void)
{
    /* Le canvas est mappé à 12 Go ; fb[y*w + x] = 0x00RRGGBB. */
    unsigned *fb = kapi_create_window (300, 200, "exemple");

    g_label = kapi_add_label (10, 10, 200, 16, "prêt");
    (void) kapi_add_button (10, 40, 80, 28, "OK", on_ok);
```

```

kapi_wait_for_exit (); /* pompe les événements à ~60 fps jusqu'à fermeture */
return 0;
}

```

Key points:

- **kapi_create_window(w, h, title)** returns a pointer to the **canvas** (pixel buffer of 0x00RRGGBB, width w). The app draws directly into it (no per-pixel call). The variant **kapi_create_window_ex(x, y, w, h, title, flags)** is for explicit placement and **WIN_FLAG_BORDERLESS**.
- **Kernel widgets:** **kapi_add_button/label/checkbox/textbox/progress/slider/textarea/scrollbar_v/scrollbar_h/icon(...)** return an unsigned long handle. Manipulate them with **kapi_widget_set_text/get_text, get_checked, get/set_value, set_rect** (move/hide by setting w=h=0), **set_icon**.
- **Event loop:** either **kapi_wait_for_exit()** (blocking, simple), or your own loop **while (!kapi_should_exit()) { ...; kapi_pump_events(); kapi_present(); kapi_msleep(16); }** when you animate the canvas yourself.
- **App-drawn UI:** to draw text over your canvas, use **kapi_draw_text(x, y, s, color) + kapi_font_width/height()**. Capture the keyboard with **kapi_set_key_handler(fn)** (**GUI_EVENT_KEY** events, **KEY_***/ASCII values) and the "outside-widget" clicks with **kapi_set_click_handler(fn)** (**GUI_EVENT_CANVAS_CLICK / ..._MOTION**, coordinates encoded in value). Cursor position relative to the window: **kapi_cursor_pos(&x, &y)**.
- **Cooperative:** your app **must yield** regularly (**present/msleep/ pump_events/wait_for_exit**), otherwise it freezes the whole system.

See the demos **demoD.c** (widget gallery), **demoE.c** (textarea + scrollview), and the apps **tinypad.c**, **paint.c**, **mandelbrot.c** for complete examples.

7. Writing a /bin tool

A **/bin** tool follows the **same EL1 app model** but reads **stdin**, writes **stdout**, and exits (no window). It is composable via the terminal's pipes.

```

#include "kapi.h"
#include "applib.h" /* ax_puts, ax_putln, ax_strlen, ax_itoa, ... */

int main (void)
{
    char args[128];
    kapi_get_args (args, sizeof args); /* La ligne d'arguments (chaîne) */

    /* Lire stdin et le réécrire en majuscules, par exemple : */
    char buf[256];
    int n;
    while ((n = kapi_stdin_read (buf, sizeof buf)) > 0)
    {
        for (int i = 0; i < n; i++)
            if (buf[i] >= 'a' && buf[i] <= 'z') buf[i] -= 32;
        kapi_stdout_write (buf, (unsigned) n);
    }
    return 0; /* code de sortie récupérable via kapi_wait dans l'appelant */
}

```

- `kapi_get_args(buf, size)`: the entire argument line as a **single string** separated by spaces (there is no `argv` array; parse the first word yourself, etc.).
- `kapi_stdin_read(buf, n)`: reads the task's stdin (`0 = EOF`). `kapi_stdout_write`: writes stdout.
- To read a file passed as an argument: `kapi_open/read/close`. To list a directory: `kapi_opendir/readdir/closedir`.

The existing tools to study: `ls`, `cat`, `grep`, `wc`, `echo`, `page`, `rm`, `mkdir`, `touch`, `cp`, `mv`, `ps`, `kill`, `run`, `keyb` (in `user/bin/`).

8. The `applib.h` library

`user/applib.h` is **header-only** (no `libc`). It provides:

- **Strings**: `ax_strlen`, `ax_streq`, `ax_strcat(dst, cap, &pos, src)` (concat without overflow), `ax_app_path(dst, cap, name, suffix)` (builds `SD:apps/<name><suffix>`), `ax_itoa(v, buf)`, `ax_fmt2(d, v)` (2-digit decimal).
- **Console**: `ax_puts(s)`, `ax_putln(s)` (to stdout).
- A minimal **.ini reader**: `app_ini_load("config.ini")` (from the app's folder via `kapi_app_dir`) or `app_ini_load_path("SD:skins/theme.txt")`; then `app_ini_get(section, key, default)` and `app_ini_get_int(...)`. Sections `[xxx]`, lines `key=value`, comments `;/#`.
- **App-drawn widgets** (not kernel widgets): `ax_dropdown` (drop-down list) and `ax_colorpick` (palette-based color picker), with `*_draw(...)` and `*_click(...)`. The app draws them in its canvas and routes the clicks via its `set_click_handler`. Used by `theme.c` and `mandelbrot.c`.

There is also `user/httpc.h` — a header-only **HTTP/1.0 client** over the v21 TCP socket calls. It does **no allocation** (the caller passes the response buffer, so all memory stays in the app's address space): `http_get(url, buf, cap, &resp)`, `http_post(...)`, or the general `http_request(method, url, headers, body, len, buf, cap, &resp)`. Plain HTTP only (no TLS). Used by `/bin/wget`. This is the recommended pattern for application-level protocols: build them in a user library on top of the kernel's transport `kapis`, rather than adding them to the ABI.

And `user/uikit.h` — a **retained-mode widget toolkit** drawn entirely in the app's canvas, driven by the kernel's **pointer stream** (ABI v22: `set_pointer_handler` → `GUI_EVENT_PTR_MOVE/DOWN/UP/ENTER/LEAVE` with client coords). Same memory model as the rest: widgets live in a caller-provided **fixed pool** (`ui_widget pool[N]` in the app's `.bss`, freed automatically on exit — no user `malloc`, no kernel object behind a widget). `ui_init`, `ui_button/ui_label/ui_checkbox`, `ui_on_event` (fed from the app's pointer + key handlers), `ui_draw`. `tinycalc` uses it. This is the forward path for widgets: new ones are added here, in userland, with no kernel/ABI change. The older **kernel-drawn widgets** (`add_button...`, §earlier) still work and coexist; apps choose one model per window.

Dynamic memory + C++ apps

Apps have **no `malloc` by default** — they use static buffers + the stack (both in the app's address space). For dynamic memory, include `user/umm.h`: a small user allocator (size-class free lists + a `kapi_sbrk` arena). `umm_malloc` / `umm_free` / `umm_calloc` / `umm_realloc`. The heap lives at `USER_HEAP_BASE` (10 GB); its pages are owned by the address space, so they are **freed automatically when the app exits** and show up in the app's page count (`ps` / `memmon`). `kapi_sbrk` is the underlying primitive (rarely called directly). `/bin/heaptest` exercises it.

C++ apps are supported (freestanding subset — no exceptions, no RTTI, no STL):

- Name the source *.cpp; the user Makefile builds it with g++ (-fno-exceptions -fno-rtti -fno-threadsafe-statics -fno-use-cxa-atexit).
- Include user/onyxpp.hpp: it defines operator new/delete (on umm) and the runtime stubs (__cxa_pure_virtual, __dso_handle, __cxa_atexit/atexit no-ops). Global constructors run via crt0.S (the .init_array walk); static destructors are **not** run (the app exits and its address space is reclaimed).
- Classes, inheritance and virtual methods (vtables) work; new/delete go through the user heap. No std::string/std::vector — write small containers on umm as needed. See user/cppdemo.cpp for a working example.

9. Packaging an app: .app, icons, config.ini

Layout of an application on the card (produced by make stage):

```
SD:apps/<nom>.app/
main.elf      1'ELF de l'app (obligatoire)
icon.bmp      icône 40×40, BMP 24 bpp ; le magenta 0xFF00FF est transparent (optionnel)
config.ini     configuration de l'app, lue via app_ini_load() (optionnel)
```

The **app name** is the base name of the .app folder (without the suffix). That is what you put in autostart.txt/quicklaunch.txt and what kapi_list_apps returns.

Icons — tools/gen_assets.py procedurally generates the 40×40 BMPs (BGR bottom-up, 4-byte padding) for all the apps (a document for tinypad, a calculator for tinycalc, a glider for life, etc.) and the "9 squares" glyph of the apps button in the panel. tools/preview_icons.py produces a PNG preview montage. Workflow: run gen_assets.py (writes the icon.bmp files into sdcard/apps/<name>.app/), then preview_icons.py to check visually.

config.ini — example read by inidemo / voronoy / panel:

```
; commentaire
greeting = bonjour
[app]
name = Mon App
version = 1
[display]
barwidth = 40
```

Screenshots and documentation

- **Screenshots (simulated but faithful):** tools/screenshot/render.py loads the **real** skins (SD:skins/wings/button/closebgs.bmp), the **real** font circle/lib/font8x16.cpp and the icons SD:apps/<name>.app/icon.bmp, and reproduces the drawing routine of each app — so the output matches the real OS. Run python tools/screenshot/render.py → writes the PNGs into screenshots/ (desktop.png = overview, plus one screenshot per app, window only on a transparent background). **To add an app:** write app_<name>() that reproduces the redraw() of user/<name>.c (same colors/coords), add ("<name>", app_<name>) to the APPS list, and re-run.
- **Word/PDF exports:** docs/build_docs.py converts each .md in docs/ into .docx (via pandoc) then into .pdf (via Word/docx2pdf), in docs/exports/. Run python docs/build_docs.py after any modification to the .md files. Prerequisites (once): pip install python-docx docx2pdf py pandoc_binary.

- **Reminder of the project rule** (see `CLAUDE.md`): any modification of a `kapi` function or of an app **updates the docs in the same go**, regenerates the affected screenshot if the visual changes, then regenerates the exports.

10. Extending the `kapi` ABI

The ABI is **append-only**. To add a kernel function callable by apps, there are **5 points** to touch (all in the same direction, at the end):

1. `kernel/include/kern/kapi_abi.h` — add the function pointer **at the end** of `struct TKApiTable` (never in the middle, never reorder), with a version comment, and **increment** `KAPI_ABI_VERSION`.

```
// --- v22 additions --- (next free version; v21 added the TCP sockets)
int (*ma_fonction) (int arg);
```

2. `kernel/sys/kapi.cpp` — implement `extern "C" int kapi_ma_fonction(int arg)`. It runs in the app's context (use `CurrentAS()` for the current address space if needed).
3. `kernel/sys/kapitable.cpp` — declare the `extern "C"` prototype and **assign the pointer** in `KApiTableInit(): t->ma_fonction = kapi_ma_fonction;`.
4. `user/kapi.h` — add the inline wrapper:

```
static inline int kapi_ma_fonction (int arg) { return KT->ma_fonction (arg); }
```

5. Rebuild (`make`). The apps that want the new function use it; the old ones keep working (they ignore the new field).

Golden rule: never change the signature or the order of an existing field. If some semantics must change, add a **new** entry. An app can query `((const struct TKApiTable *)KAPI_TABLE_VA)->version` to find out what is available.

If you add a new **GUI event** or a **window flag**, keep the values synchronized between `kernel/gui/window.h` and the `#defines` in `user/kapi.h` (commented "must match").

11. Coding conventions

- **Kernel (C++)**: Circle style. `CXxx` classes, `m_Xxx` members, CamelCase methods, `boolean/TRUE/FALSE` and Circle's `u8/u16/u32/u64` types. No exceptions or RTTI. `new/delete` go through Circle's heap.
- **Userland (C)**: freestanding C. `ax_` prefix for the `applib.h` helpers. Globals `g_xxx`. Bounded static buffers (no dynamic allocation on the app side in general).
- **kapi**: `extern "C"` functions named `kapi_xxx` on the kernel side; inline wrappers `kapi_xxx` on the app side.
- Respect the **comment density** and the **idiom** of the file you are modifying.
- **Git**: commit into the **Onyx repo** explicitly — the current working directory (cwd) drifts; a bare `git` may land in the wrong repo. (Note: `circle/` is not committed in this repo.)

12. Debugging on hardware

Bring-up is done **directly on the Pi 4** (no QEMU raspi4b). Tools:

- **On-screen exception dump:** an EL1 synchronous fault (or an EL0 fault) paints a panic + register dump on the HDMI framebuffer (`PanicToScreen` + Circle's handler). Note the `ELR` (faulting PC).
- **addr2line:** `aarch64-none-elf-addr2line -e kernel8-rpi4.elf <ELR>` to locate the faulting line (keep the unstripped `.elf` next to the `.img`).
- **Serial console:** `config.txt` must have `enable_uart=1` (PL011 clock). The boot log goes **also** to the HDMI screen (`CScreenDevice`) so it is readable without a serial cable.
- **Post-mortem console:** on an app's exit, the compositor clears and the logger is shown on the framebuffer (see [Kernel internals §11](#)).

13. Known pitfalls

- **Do not save FP/SIMD.** `-mgeneral-regs-only` is mandatory on the app side; use fixed-point. An accidental floating-point use would corrupt the state on a context switch.
- **L3 tables shared with the kernel.** On the kernel side, never free an L3 table from the user area without checking that it is not shared with the kernel's L2 (cf. [Kernel internals §4](#)). Otherwise: global corruption.
- **Do not free the ABI table page.** It is global to the kernel; the destruction of an address space already skips it.
- **DEPTH=32 for Circle.** `GImage` renders 32-bit; forgetting `-d DEPTH=32` (or changing `DEPTH` without `make clean` in `circle/lib`) gives wrong colors/breakage.
- **Cooperative.** Any app loop without `present/msleep/yield` freezes the system (no preemption).
- **Circle LF renormalization.** On Windows, Circle is checked out in CRLF; renormalize once (cf. §2) otherwise the build breaks.
- **The right Circle.** Patch `Zircon/circle`, not another clone.